

PSYC100: General Psychology

Modules 1 - 10: Complete Study Guide

Milestone 1: Foundations & Experimental Frameworks

Psychology is formally defined as the scientific study of mind and behavior. Its primary objective is to move beyond casual intuition by employing empirical methods to observe, track, and measure mental processes and their outward expressions.

Lesson 1: Defining the Scope & Core Dualities

The field originates from a fundamental pairing: tracking what occurs internally within the mind (the cognitive thought process) alongside observable, physical actions (behavior).

■ Expanded Content: The Four Main Psychological Goals

- **Describe (What happens?):** Observing a behavioral phenomenon and detailing its characteristics accurately.
- **Explain (Why does it happen?):** Identifying the underlying causes, mechanisms, or drivers behind the behavior.
- **Predict (When will it happen next?):** Utilizing historical data trends to forecast future occurrences.
- **Control/Influence (Can we change it?):** Applying validated empirical insights to alter or shape real-world behavior.

```
# Practical Application: Smartwatch Break Reminder App Design
# Goal: Control/Influence behavior by modifying environmental cues.
def schedule_reminder(user_stress_index, time_since_break):
    if user_stress_index > 7.5 or time_since_break >= 120:
        return "Trigger break notification immediately"
    return "Maintain background monitoring loop"
```

Lessons 2 & 3: Historical Milestones & Structural Shifts

The formal evolution of modern psychological science is marked by a series of foundational shifts, transitioning from examining internal consciousness components to tracking pure behavior, before ultimately synthesizing both via information-processing models.

■ Expanded Content: Major Historical Paradigms

- **Wilhelm Wundt (Leipzig, 1879):** Structuralism. Focused on breaking down and measuring the basic parts of the mind using a ticking chronograph.
- **William James (1890s):** Functionalism. Focused on the functions of consciousness, examining how mental processes help humans adapt and survive.
- **Sigmund Freud (1900s):** Psychoanalysis. Centered entirely on unconscious motives—hidden thoughts and drives shaping conscious behavior.
- **Watson & Skinner (1920s–1950s):** Behaviorism. Declared observable actions as king, dismissing internal unobservable mental processes.

- **The Cognitive Revolution (1960s+):** Reframed the human mind as an information processor, explicitly comparing it to a computer.

Milestone 2: The Applied Power of the Situation

Social context can drastically reshape individual choices, often overriding personal ethics, internal beliefs, or established moral standards in a matter of hours.

Lessons 4 & 5: Obedience, Authority, and Milgram's Paradigm

Milgram's classic 1961 obedience setup demonstrated that ordinary citizens would continue administering dangerous, escalating shocks to an innocent learner simply because they were commanded to do so by an authority figure.

```
# Milgram Compliance Metrics Simulation
def evaluate_obedience_level(voltage_reached):
    if voltage_reached >= 300:
        return "Blind Obedience: Complies despite audible protests"
    elif voltage_reached >= 150:
        return "Hesitation Boundary: Expresses doubt but continues"
    return "Autonomous State: Retains individual agency"
```

Lessons 6, 7 & 8: Institutional Review Boards & Research Ethics

Public outrage following high-stress experiments led directly to the creation of strict research ethics rules and Institutional Review Boards (IRBs) to act as watchful guardians over participant well-being.

■ Expanded Content: The Core Research Safeguards

1. Informed Consent: Explicitly detailing the study's purpose and risks before volunteers sign up.
2. Right to Withdraw: Guaranteeing participants can leave the study at any time without penalty or reduced compensation.
3. Protection from Harm: Enforcing strict monitoring protocols to prevent physical or emotional distress.
4. Debriefing: Revealing any hidden deceptions immediately after the study and providing support.

```
# IRB Compliance Checker Model
def review_proposal(has_consent, has_penalty_free_withdrawal, risk_ratio):
    if not has_consent or not has_penalty_free_withdrawal:
        return "REJECTED: Severe violation of individual respect"
    if risk_ratio > 0.15:
        return "REQUIRES CHANGES: Beneficence threshold crossed"
    return "APPROVED: Ethical safeguards verified"
```

Milestone 3: Group Dynamics & The Resistance Toolkit

Understanding how groups dilute individual responsibility or pressure choices allows us to construct actionable strategies to protect our personal agency.

Lessons 9 & 10: Conformity, Bystander Effects, and Self-Deception

Conformity operates through two distinct forces: normative influence (conforming to fit in and be liked) and informational influence (conforming because you believe the group knows more than you do).

Social Phenomenon	Core Psychological Driver	Real-World Resistance Tactic
Unanimous Peer Pressure	Normative Influence	Recruit or voice a single voice of dissent.
The Bystander Effect	Diffusion of Responsibility	Take the first visible action or isolate an individual.
Blind Obedience	Authority Cue Dominance	Pause for clarity and ask for objective evidence.
Groupthink Defect	Harmony Over Evaluation	Appoint a devil's advocate to break false consensus.

```
# Reframe Technique: Overcoming Self-Deception & Fear of Rejection
def reframe_thought(negative_input):
    if negative_input == "I'll never get a job":
        return "Finding a job can be hard, but every application sent increases my chances."
    return negative_input
```